entered the world. Captain Anup Kumar Saxena made sure he was available to tend to all the needs and demands of his pregnant wife as best he could. He had liaised with the cantonment's administrative officer and gotten accommodation that was close to the Military Hospital in Narangi. He had stocked the refrigerator with his wife's favourite food items; a timetable for regular medical check-ups and medicines was scribbled into his diary. It was not only his wife who formed the epicentre of his concerns. He yearned for a girl this time, a girl he would raise the way he wished to. His mother, my grandmother, had not let him have his way with the first child. She did not believe in modern parenting techniques. But he was hell-bent on raising his second child the way he thought right, and to make sure he succeeded in his mission, he spent hours reading Dr Benjamin Spock's books on parenting to understand the physical and emotional aspects of a child and the dynamics of a family. This, however, was opposed by his orthodox mother again, but this time, he would just not listen.

Mrs Saxena, my mother, entered the ninth month of her pregnancy in the last week of August 1974. There had been a pinkish glow on her face for weeks. 'She's eager to come out now,' Papaji commented when my mother told him the baby had just kicked.

'She? Why not he?' she teased him, gazing out at rain-washed trees from their bedroom's window. 'Mother is not going to approve of your friend Spock's advice,' Maa said. 'Do you think she'll allow us to have a different room for the baby?'

'I'll not argue with her this time,' a determined Papaji replied.

'You know her temperament,' Maa said.

'And you can take care of it—like you always do,' Papaji retorted.

'Okay . . . Okay . . . I'll try,' she said, and continued in a murmur, 'dealing with everyone's temperament seems to be my only job in this house.'

'Did you say something?'

A sudden rush of pain changed her facial expressions. 'The baby's coming,' Maa said. She grabbed her belly and stood up.